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ASIAN AMERICAN STUDIES DEPARTMENT
3332 ROLFE HALL, BOX 957225
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA 90095-7225
PHONE: (310) 267-5592
FAX: (310) 267-5590
http://www.asianam.ucla.edu

February 4, 2026

Dear Selection Committee,

I enthusiastically recommend Christina Toma for UCLA's Distinguished Teaching Award. As former chair of International Development Studies (IDS) (2022-25) and faculty instructor for two IDS courses, in which Christina served as a Teaching Assistant, I can say with confidence that Christina excelled in every aspect of her role.

I met Christina in Winter 2023, when she served as one of two TAs for my large, lecture-based course "Culture, Power and Development" (IDS 110). The course equips students with theoretical frameworks and empirical tools for analyzing social, cultural, and political processes that shape global economic inequality and poverty.

As a PhD student specializing in international and comparative education, Christina was one of those rare graduate instructors who combined a strong command of the subject with an exceptional commitment to student-centered learning. She consistently went above and beyond by incorporating innovative instructional technologies, designing creative activities, and demonstrating responsiveness that was especially invaluable during unexpected disruptions to learning associated with global political events.

When I taught the course in Fall 2025, Christina supported significant changes to the content and format in response to shifts in international development and the increasing use of generative AI. She was instrumental in implementing these adjustments, particularly the transition from take-home assignments to in-class exams and structured roundtable discussions. She also prepared students for in-class presentations and encouraged students with strong writing skills to develop their public speaking skills.

Reviewing Christina's SET assessments submitted for this nomination confirmed what I already knew: Christina's work as a TA is truly exceptional. I highlight several areas of excellence below.

Christina's instructional strength is evident in her command of course material and her ability to make complex concepts accessible. She regularly expanded on lecture material, clarified key ideas, and used relevant examples that helped students engage with challenging content. Christina also took on a lead TA role by guiding colleagues through course material, co-planning

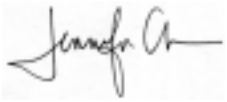
sections, and sharing resources.

A defining feature of Christina's teaching is her exceptional discussion facilitation. Students repeatedly highlight her skill in mediating interactive conversations, particularly around politically and emotionally charged material. She allows students to drive conversations while guiding them back to core concepts through synthesis and connection-building, fostering inclusion and meaningful dialogue.

Christina's pedagogy is grounded in care. Students frequently mention her attentiveness to their emotional and academic well-being, noting her willingness to organize evening review sessions, advocate for extended deadlines, and remain available during stressful periods. She creates an environment that contextualizes difficult global issues critically while approaching teaching with humility.

In sum, I offer my unequivocal and strongest recommendation for Christina. She combines intellectual depth, pedagogical creativity, and genuine care for students in ways that are rare at any level of teaching. Students leave her sections not only with a stronger grasp of the course material but also with greater confidence, curiosity, and the capacity for critical engagement. Christina is, in her student's words, "an extremely effective TA who wanted nothing but success for all students"— an educator whose impact is both profound and enduring.

Sincerely,



Jennifer Jihye Chun
Professor, Asian American Studies, Labor Studies and the International Institute
Chair, Department of Labor Studies

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

Name: Teyoltlahui Gonzalez

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I had the utmost pleasure of learning from Christina Toma as a mentor, a teacher, and a teaching assistant. I first met her as my teacher for my first international development class and deliberately chose her to be my teaching assistant during my first upper division international development studies class.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

I had no idea what international development really meant when I first started. Development itself is what we call a contested project, so simplicity was never the aim of our class conversations. Christina showed me both the light and the darkness of international development, giving us a comprehensible understanding. As an online summer class, I had very low expectations for my connection to my peers. I was pleasantly surprised to see that from the start of the class, Christina brought every single one of us to escape the grey box, turn on our cameras, and share. Being in such an interdisciplinary major means that everyone goes into it with varying interests and paths. So, choosing to engage, struggle, and grapple the course content with others made the material and my experience so much more enjoyable. After class, I tended to stick around and ask Christina questions. No matter how random the question was, Christina was honest, kind, and generous with these check-ins. She showed me that my major is a soft skill, and recommended me to find what hard skills I would like to pair it with, which I was able to soon clarify after reflecting with her.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Christina is very intentional and expressive, which even online, made it much easier to add emphasis to core ideas. Rather than keeping the traditional lecture style the whole class, she dedicated a generous amount of time every class for us to grapple with questions and activities together in groups. Since every group had their own designation, we were then able to divide and conquer and most importantly, share. Presenting during an online class used to be a challenge for me. Yet in this class, it was normalized and comfortable. I especially found it useful that every week, we were able to exchange our groups and get to know the entire class little by little. As mentioned before, this allowed me to recognize perspectives I never would have thought of before because of our varying backgrounds. Aside from our well-planned group work, Christina made sure to visualize our topics and bring forward the different ways they connected to one another, especially in the relation to our course. In this way, we reflected our knowledge in how it has been built, contested, broken, and rebuilt, like physical lego pieces that don't look like they'll fit but eventually do.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

I picked Christina as my teaching assistant last quarter not because I was comfortable, but because she helped get me uncomfortable. Christina taught me to analyze, listen, share, and reflect. Christina set my standard for an amazing teaching assistant, with her preparedness and intentionality for our discussions. During our time in the summer and in my upper division course, she gave her all, constantly supporting student's needs equally. In only 6 weeks, our class covered authors and ideas that even our upper division professor was impressed and taken aback by. I hope her nomination is given the utmost consideration.

Distinguished Teaching Award for Christina Toma - Structured Question Template

I was unable to fit my responses in the provided boxes, despite not exceeding the word count so I've put them here.

Name: Ria Casas

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)
I had the wonderful opportunity of learning under Christina's constant support and guidance as a Teaching Assistant during a summer session course for IDS1 and then again this past Fall 2025 for another upper division International Development Studies course.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

I've always felt secure in STEM, but wanted to explore my curiosity for the world of IDS, but had my doubts. Entering the course, it felt as though everyone else knew everything about everything. My self-doubts intensified and I felt discouraged, thinking I should stick with "what I know". Christina created an environment I felt comfortable asking questions, even when my interpretations weren't quite right. I struggled taking abstract ideas too literally, but she never made me feel embarrassed or discouraged. Instead, she helped redirect my thinking, fostering my "IDS mind" and helping me approach material with greater nuance and confidence. That growth made me feel like I truly had a place in IDS. My confidence grew in ways I didn't expect, not only within IDS, but in my understanding of the world as an adult. Engaging with current global issues alongside historical context gave me an awareness and perspective I hadn't previously experienced. For the first time, I felt confident in my ability to understand what's happening in the world and why it mattered, which filled me with pride. Christina helped me realize that I had something to contribute, marking a defining moment in my academic and personal development.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

One of the most beneficial things Christina did as a Teaching Assistant was actively seek out and genuinely incorporate student feedback. She asked for our input and made it clear

that our perspectives mattered, which created a sense of mutual respect in the classroom. Her willingness to listen made the learning experience feel collaborative. She also prioritized engaging, hands-on activities, and meaningful peer discussions, which helped students understand the material through application with activities that got us moving around the class and discussing/collaborating with our peers. Breakout rooms were used frequently, which allowed students to breakdown complex readings together in smaller, more comfortable settings where we built up our confidence to speak in the larger rooms which I appreciated. These discussions deepened the understanding of the material and made concepts feel more accessible. Additionally, Christina made herself consistently available to students. Beyond scheduled office hours, she was highly responsive to emails and never made it feel as though we were inconveniencing her. Her approachability gave me the confidence to ask questions and seek clarification when I needed it. Knowing that she genuinely cared about student learning made a significant difference in my engagement and understanding of the course material.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

I want to emphasize I never strayed from the comfort of STEM, but IDS was in the back of my mind, I just didn't know why and I emailed Christina about this new world of IDS and she took a genuine interest in my journey and this is what led me to solidify the decision and enroll. I genuinely felt so discouraged the first weeks of class and I was ready to give up because nothing was sticking in my head. Through Christina’s support and encouragement, my confidence grew and although I’m not pursuing the major, her mentorship inspired me to continue IDS courses and pursue a global health minor.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name: Parker Watson

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

It is my pleasure to recommend Christina Toma for this award. I had the privilege of being a student in two sections with Christina, and in both, I experienced the same level of care and commitment. She was my TA for International and Area Studies 1 and International Development 140.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Christina consistently inspired students through her ability to bring complex international topics to life. She took broad concepts and made them specific, setting students up for exam success through a deep understanding of course material. Christina's passion for the subject played a significant role in my own academic path. Through her teaching, I developed a stronger interest in international development, which ultimately led me to choose a double major in International Development Studies. This decision was directly influenced by the way Christina presented the field and its importance.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

One of Christina's greatest strengths was her ability to mediate complex and interactive discussions. While many TAs facilitate discussion, Christina was particularly effective at bridging ideas between students and fostering meaningful dialogue. She allowed students to drive the conversation while skilfully guiding discussion to ensure clarity and inclusion. Her background in education was evident in the way she structured discussions and responded to student contributions. She builds on comments, asks follow-up questions, and connects our

perspectives back to core course concepts. Christina consistently created an environment where all students felt included and valued, and where participation enhanced understanding of course concepts rather than simply filling time. Her sections are genuinely engaging, creative, and never boring.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

What distinguishes Christina most is how deeply she cares about both the subject she teaches and the students she teaches it to. She consistently demonstrated a commitment to student learning through her preparation, feedback, and approachability. Her impact on my academic experience was so significant that I intentionally enrolled in another course with her and reached out before the quarter began when I saw her listed as the TA. For these reasons, I strongly believe Christina is deserving of the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

Sincerely,

Parker Watson

January 28, 2026

To Whom It May Concern,
It is with great pleasure that I endorse Christina Toma for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

I am a former MA/MSW student in a concurrent program of Asian American Studies and Social Welfare. I had the privilege of teaching alongside Christina as a TA in IDS 110 during the Fall of 2023. As a graduate student from a non-teaching background with no prior experience in International Development, I benefited greatly from Christina's depth of knowledge and experience. She acted as a mentor to me, generously guiding me through both the subject matter and effective pedagogical strategies.

Christina took the lead in planning discussion sections, responding to unforeseen circumstances, and coordinating our work together. Her leadership was instrumental, and without her support, I would have struggled to navigate the course.

Graduate students are notoriously busy and overwhelmed, particularly those in Ph.D. programs. And while I am sure this is true for Christina, she never hesitated to take on extra work, answer my questions, or respond to student requests. At the start of the quarter, she shared one of her former syllabi as an example for me to utilize. She was always prepared with lesson plans that she happily shared. When I asked clarifying questions, she took the time to explain how she envisioned an activity.

When reflecting on my UCLA undergraduate experience, few TAs stand out like Christina. Her sections consistently incorporated creative activities, such as Jamboard to facilitate cross-section collaboration or videos illustrating real-world examples of course content. One of students' favorite activities was a participatory budgeting debate. Christina planned a lesson in which students worked together to write proposals for changes they'd like to see on campus. Students persuasively pitched many ideas about campus improvements and engaged in lively debate before voting on the best ones. In adopting and facilitating this activity, I could point to how Christina intentionally planned and thoughtfully designed lessons that replicated real community work.

Though there is much more I can write about Christina's pedagogy, what stands out to me most about her is her empathy and compassion towards students. Fall 2023 was a particularly challenging quarter for many of her students. From personal conflicts like sexual harassment, family emergencies, and health concerns, no less than 10 of her students faced extenuating circumstances. Despite being inundated with student requests and emails, Christina consistently provided unwavering support, accommodation, and understanding to each student. She graciously offered deadline extensions, connected students to campus resources, and provided a listening ear.

Christina's dedication to her students shines through every aspect of her work. Whether crafting lesson plans, organizing activities, or meeting with students, her concern is their well-being. From coordinating late-evening final review sessions to advocating for extended deadlines, Christina consistently prioritizes her students' best interests. It's this level of care and excellence that makes her teaching so memorable, even years later.

Sincerely,
Kristi Mai
Mental Health Clinician at the LA Downtown Women's Center
kristivmai@gmail.com